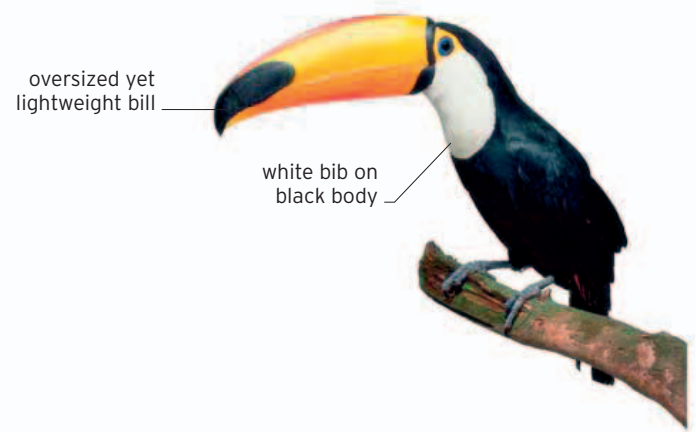




Toco toucan

Ramphastos toco

Few birds worldwide are as instantly recognizable as the toco toucan, with its huge, colorful bill. The long bill is useful for reaching fruit on the ends of branches that are too thin to support the toucan's weight. It can also be used to grab small reptiles, eggs and nestlings, and large insects, if fruit is scarce. The bill's bright color must act as a visual stimulus in social situations, although it is identical in both sexes. It also serves as a striking warning to predators.

Cool discovery

Scientists have recently discovered another use for the toco toucan's enormous bill: it has an important function as a radiator. When temperatures are high, the toucan can lose up to 60 percent of its body heat through the bill, which has a network of blood vessels

The toco toucan has the **largest bill of any bird**, relative to body size

that controls the flow of blood to its surface. In cool spells, the blood flow is restricted, allowing the toucan to conserve its body heat. During the night, it sleeps with the bill under a wing, to maintain heat.

Tocos are weak fliers. They flutter through the forest canopy, usually in pairs, to find fruiting trees. Tree cavities are often enlarged for the nest, in which two to four eggs are incubated by both parents. They defend the chicks from predators, such as snakes, as it takes several months for a chick's bill to be fully formed.

▽ PROMINENT BILL

Despite its size, the toco toucan's bill is comparatively light because it is mostly hollow, with a supporting framework of bony struts.

